

The best way to avoid unnecessary trips is to keep a detailed grocery or supply list and whenever you're low on an item, write it down. I am the queen of unnecessary errands because I often run out of something I've forgotten to put on the list!

But if you do forget to pick up an ingredient for dinner that night, don't be afraid to get creative. I've saved many a meal just by searching for a substitution on Google, or changing dinner plans based on what we already had in the pantry.

READER TIP:

The two main saving strategies for our family are staying home and batching errands. It takes us several minutes to get to the freeway and to our main shopping center so we make sure we really need to go out before we head into town.

—Julia, MN

3. USE ALTERNATIVE TRANSPORTATION

Not all of us live near a downtown or metropolitan area, but for those who do, try walking or riding your bike the next time you need to get something. It will take a little bit longer to get where you need to go, but on the flipside, it's an opportunity to slow down in this fast-paced world and savor the everyday. It can also be a great way to get out of the house for a while and stretch your legs.

If you do decide to walk or ride your bike, try to have the proper equipment with you, such as a basket for your bike, or sturdy reusable bags to carry. I once lost a few cans of pasta sauce on my way home from the grocery store because the plastic ones couldn't carry all that weight!

The bus, train, subway, or carpooling with friends is another great way to get around town without using your vehicle. It might feel like you're losing a little bit of your independence when you have to rely on the schedule of a